the RSS, the Congress, Narendra Modi, Amit Shah and Rahul Gandhi from their official pages in the same period (a total of 40,251; 1.2 million words). After cleaning up the data, we created a specially developed digital analysis tool, the Narad Index, which measures how communication patterns change over time. The findings surprised us, and various chapters in the book, across subjects, are suffused with the insights we gained from them.

We further supplemented the digital archive and the Narad Index by creating a centralised digital repository of 218 interactive data dashboards, which we called 'PollNiti'. This repository consists of over 100 data-analytics dashboards on constituency-level political information from national and state elections spread over four decades of politics (1980–2019); eight economic data dashboards consisting of national and state-level economic data stretching over seven years (2012–2019); and 110 social-media-analytics dashboards tracking dozens of politicians over three years (2016–2019). Many of these data sets were drawn from public sources. Some we constructed ourselves over time.

We cleaned them all up, digitised them, linked them to each other to get a holistic understanding and added our own layering of editorial filters—rural–urban seats, Muslim-significant seats, night-light data from commercial satellite imagery to see constituency-wise patterns of economic change in the Northeast, representation of women at various levels, among others. We built over a hundred such machine-led editorial filters—all interchangeable and interactive—on top of these multiple interlinked data sets to aid analysis and to find patterns that the human eye would otherwise miss. Some of the insights gained from these new digital tools are in the book. All of them are available to researchers online at *PollNiti.com*.

Realising that data alone can sometimes be misleading or offer only a partial understanding—it can tell us the what, not the how—my collaborating researchers and I met with a range of leaders at various levels of the BJP, the RSS, the Congress and regional Opposition parties across several states. We conducted over 150 on- and off-the-record interviews and conversations at different levels of politics, from the ground up to high-management levels, and with domain experts in several Indian states. I thought this would be